

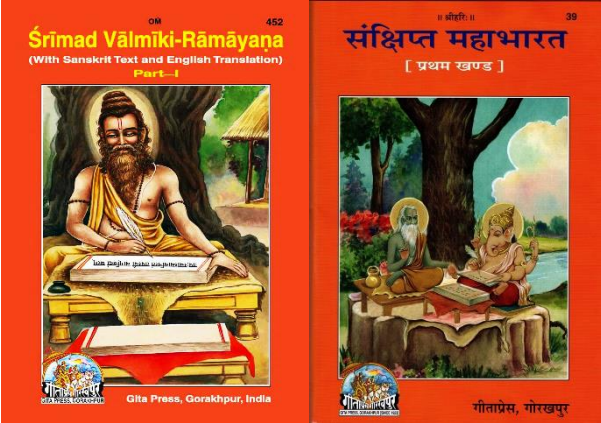
Dilemmas in the Life of Indian Heroes Yudhishtir, Vibhishan, Bhishm & Karna

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Introduction: Understanding Dilemmas

- “A situation in which a difficult choice has to be made between two equally important but conflicting moral principles.” is called Dilemma.
- A dilemma is a situation where a person is torn between two important but conflicting choices. It often involves questions of truth vs. loyalty, duty vs. desire, or compassion vs. personal benefit.
- In ancient Indian epics, great heroes also faced dilemmas — and their decisions shaped the course of history. Through their stories, we learn that how we choose in crisis reveals who we truly are.

Importance of Epics in Guiding Us Through Our Dilemmas



The epics Ramayana and Mahabharata are the foundational base of not only Bharat but entire mankind.

Hence for the epics it is said that:

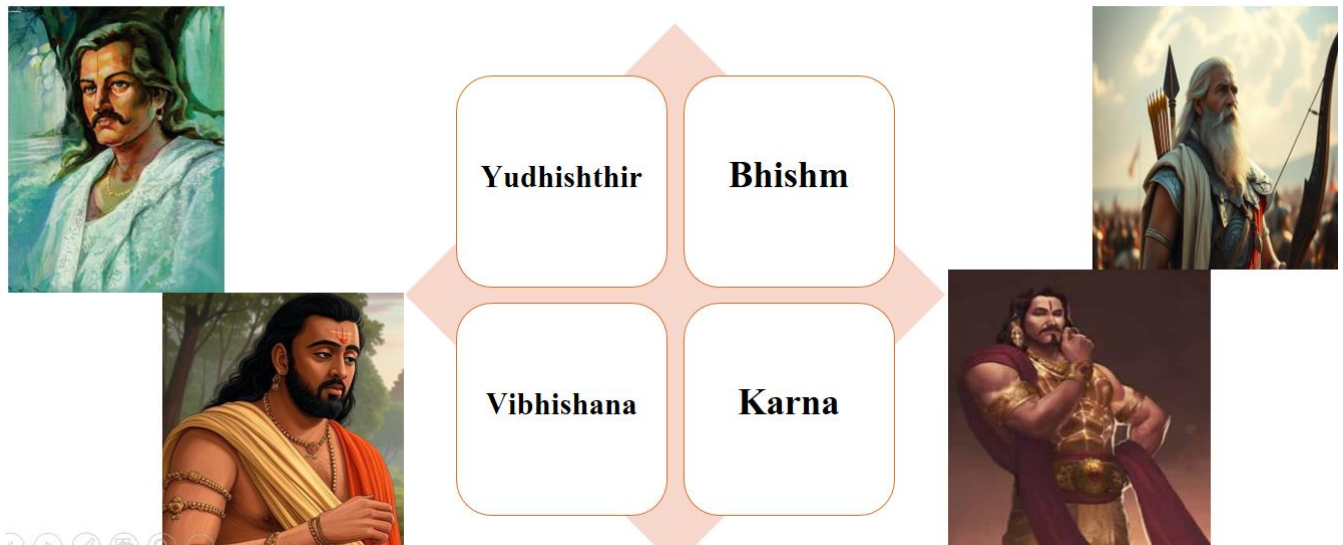
“यदीहास्ति तदन्यत्र यन्नेहास्ति न तत् क्वचित्”

“Whatever is here (in the Mahabharata) is found everywhere, what is not here is not found anywhere.”

It is a psychological need of any person to look up to some role model or hero whenever in dilemma of problem. Which is why we always look back to epics as it has the ideal heroes and ideal situations which guide us as to how to behave in what kind of situation.

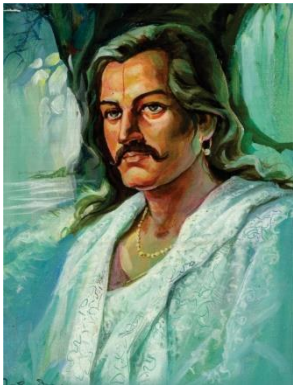
Human problems today are no different than past. An age old epics are relevant even today because they show us the solution to the problems which evolved since the human existence evolved.

Here also, to understand what is dilemma and how to find a solution whenever we are in dilemmas, we are taking help of Indian heroes from the epics- Yudhishtir, Vibhishan, Bhishma and Karna.



Let us evaluate the dilemmas of each of these Indian heroes and observe what did they choose when they were in dilemmas and what were the repercussions of their preferences. Let us begin with the first hero- Yudhishtir.

1. Yudhishtir



Yudhishtir was the eldest Pandav and was also known as Dharmaraja for his sense of doing justice and dealing with things keeping *Dharma* in centre.

He also faced three conflicts in his life when he had to choose between good and greater good. Let us see how he dealt with those dilemmas.

Dilemma-Episodes from the Life of Yudhishtir

Dilemma 1: The Gambling Invitation



Yudhishtir was invited to a game of dice. As a Kshatriya king, refusing the invitation could be seen as cowardice and he might break the legacy of Kshatriya Kings. But accepting it meant risking his kingdom, brothers, and even Draupadi.

What did he choose ?

He accepted the invitation — leading to catastrophic consequences.

Why did he choose that?

He knew he might lose everything and get tricked if he accepts the gambling invitation, but he had to still choose it to maintain the legacy of Kshatriya kings, who cannot deny any sort of invitation or challenge. In the conflict between saving personal belongings and saving the clan's legacy, he chose the greater good, choosing to save the family legacy.

Dilemma 2: Ashwatthama's Death



During the war, the Pandavas needed to defeat Dronacharya. It was almost impossible to beat him in warfare, the only way out was to give him the news of his son, Ashwatthama's death; for this grief can compel Dronacharya to put down his weapons.

Krishna crafted a plot and asked Bhima to kill an elephant named Ashwatthama. They spread the news that "Ashwatthama is dead."

Dejected Drona asked Yudhishtir to validate the rejoice of Bhima, and asked him to speak the truth, whether really Ashwatthama was killed or not.

Yudhishtir faced a conflicting situation here thinking he, being a *Dharmaraja* cannot lie and deny as Ashwatthama [elephant] was actually killed, but he also thought if he would speak the truth that it is elephant who died and not Drona's son, repercussions might compel them to lose the war of Dharma.

What did he choose?

Bound by the truth, Yudhishtir spoke- "Ashwatthama is dead" and added: "man or an elephant!" but while he was speaking the other sentence, Krishna created a loud atmosphere of celebration, because of which Dronacharya could not listen to the later sentence. Thinking his son is dead he put down the weapons.

Why did he choose that?

In this conflicting situation, Yudhishtir chose to speak the twisted truth. In the conflict between speaking the truth to keep up his image and to speak twisted truth to win the war of Dharma. He chose the latter option, which is for the greater good.

Dilemma 3: Heaven and the Dog



At the gates of heaven, Yudhishtir was told by Indra, that he could enter only if he abandoned the dog that had followed him. If he disobeys the Indra's instruction, he might lose the only chance to enter heaven. If he obeys and enter the heaven without the dog, then he would betray a loyal companion and being Dharmaraja he cannot do injustice.

What did he choose?

He chose to give up heaven if it doesn't let the dog enter

Why did he choose that?

Being a Dharmaraja Yudhishtir cannot do injustice to dog who had been with him and had crossed all the hurdles to make it up to the door of heaven. He too was as much deserving as Yudhishtir. It would be *Adharmic* to leave him.

2. Vibhishan



Vibhishan is the younger brother of Ravana. Despite belonging from the same family, they both had contrary traits. Where Ravana was Adharmi and a rival of Shri Ram. There, Vibhishan was Dharmic and an ardent devotee of Shri Ram.

Let us evaluate the three dilemmas he faced in his life.

Dilemma-Episodes from the Life of Vibhishan

Dilemma 1: Should I Advise Ravana To Return Sita?



Vibhishan was knowing the repercussions if the war takes place. The only way he could see to save his kingdom was to convince Ravana to return Sita with respect and apologies.

The conflict he faced was, if he would advise Ravana to do so, he might get kicked out of the kingdom by Ravana. If he would refrain from advising Ravana, then eventually the war will destroy everything.

What did he choose ?

He advised Ravana to return Sita.

Why did he choose that?

Despite knowing the consequences of advising Ravana and going against him, he dared to advise him. What he thought was not for his own good but for the good of the people, kingdom and Ravana himself.

Dilemma 2: Should I Leave Lanka and My Family In The Time Of Need?



When Ravana gave up returning Sita, Vibhishan was left with only two options, one: whether to leave Lanka and another one: whether to stay with his family in the time of need.

What did he choose?

He chose to leave Lanka.

Why did he choose that?

He could have chosen to stay with his family in time of need and remain silent until he gets the throne after Ram kills Ravana but instead leaving behind the selfish motive he chose to leave his family even since they were Adharmic. He chose Dharma over Family.

Dilemma 3: Should I Join Ram's Army Against Ravana?



Vibhishan tried to convince Ravan to return Sita and refrain from getting indulged into war with Ram, he very well knew Ram is the embodiment of Dharma and in the end Dharma alone wins. Hence he left Lanka and Ravana in the time of need. Now again he encountered two conflicts: one is whether to stay neutral and not join either of them or to stay by the side of Dharma and join Ram's army.

What did he choose?

He chose to stay by the side of Dharma & joined Ram's army

Why did he choose that?

Staying neutral, even when you have chance to opt Dharma, is also cowardice and is again choosing Adharma. Hence Vibhishan kept Dharma all above his personal loss and filial affection.

3. Bhishm



Bhishma was the son of Shantanu and Ganga. Initially known as Devavrata was later recognized as Bhishma due to a pledge which he took to remain an ascetic lifelong for his father's happiness. Due to taking this *Bhishan* [terrific] pledge, he was then known as "Bhishma"

Let us see which three dilemmas he faced in his life.

Dilemma-Episodes from the Life of Bhishma

Dilemma 1: Should I Remain Lifelong Celibate for My Father's Happiness?



When Bhishma's biological mother Ganga left Shantanu, he became dejected and during that time he met Satyawati, daughter of a fisherman. Shantanu proposed her for marriage but her father kept a condition that only Satyawati's son will sit on the throne as a king of Hastinapur. This made Shantanu all the more confused as he already had a son from Ganga Devavrata. Devavrata had two choices in front of him, whether to remain a lifelong celibate and give up his rightful throne & personal happiness of getting married or should he fulfil his duties as a king and give up his father's happiness.

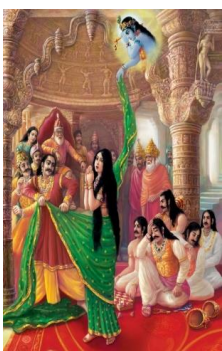
What did he choose ?

He chose the happiness of his father and took the Bhishma-Pratigya of remaining a celibate for lifetime and to always obey the king of Hastinapur.

Why did he choose that?

Indian civilization has always given importance to the greater good, in this conflict between his choosing his happiness as a king and choosing his father's happiness, Bhishma chose the greater good by choosing his father's happiness.

Dilemma 2: Should I Remain Silent During The Disrobing Of Draupadi?



When Yudhishtir was losing everything, he gambled Draupadi and eventually lost her as well. Duryodhan commanded for disrobing [Cheerharan] of Draupadi and it began in the court. Draupadi was weeping and crying to all the elders for help, including Bhishma. Bhishma faced a conflict here whether to act as an elder and stop this Adharmic act or whether to obey the king's order as per his pledge.

What did he choose?

He chose to obey the king's order and remained silent during the disrobing of Draupadi.

Why did he choose that?

He had pledged that he will always obey the king of Hastinapur. Hence for him, 'obeying the king' was more important than 'stopping the Adharmic act of Draupadi's disrobing'

When the conflict arose, instead of choosing the greater good; which is stopping the Adharmic act, he chose his pledge [Swadharma]. It should be noted here that, unlike Yudhishtir and Vibhishan, Bhishma chose himself and his pledge instead of the greater good. [Others or Kingdom]

Dilemma 3: Should I Fight From The Side Of Kauravas Despite Knowing They Are Adharmic ?



Bhishma always knew the difference between Dharmic and Adharmic intellect. He knew Kauravas got deviated from the path of Dharma which will lead them to destruction. He faced a conflict here, whether to stay with Adharmic king or to join hands with Dharmic opponent!

What did he choose?

He chose to stay loyal to the king and fought from the side of Kauravas.

Why did he choose that?

Again when Bhishma got stuck in the conflict, he chose his own self and his own pledge of 'always staying faithful to the king, under any circumstances' [even though he is Adharmic] instead of choosing the greater good of saving the kingdom from the destruction by joining the Dharmic opponent.

4. Karna



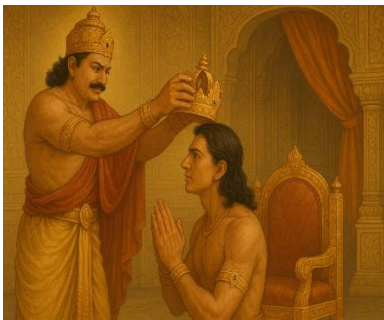
Karna was the son of Kunti and the eldest Pandava. Kunti obtained a boon from Durvasa Rishi in which she could get a son from any deity she prays to. To check the authenticity of the boon, she prayed to Suryadeva and eventually was gifted by a son, Karna, who was born with the divine armour stuck to his body naturally. Since Kunti was unmarried at that time, with the fear of defamation she gave up on that son and left him on the mercy of river. Later on he was picked up by a charioteer Adirath and raised by Radha.

Since childhood he was jealous of Arjuna and he always wanted to prove his valour by defeating Arjuna. Duryodhan who was also Arjuna's enemy joined hands with Karna and made him the king of *Ang Desh*. The sole purpose & base of their unity and friendship was to destroy and take revenge from Arjuna.

During the war, later he came to know about his true identity and the truth regarding Pandavas as his true brothers. Many people including Shri Krishna tried to convince Karna to join Pandavas and come on the side of Dharma. Here he faces three dilemmas.

Dilemma-Episodes from the Life of Karna

Dilemma 1: Should I Stay Loyal to Duryodhan or Should I Be With My Family?



When everybody rejected him, it was on Duryodhan who accepted him & gave him all the respect and fame which he always wanted. And now in the war when Duryodhan was in the dire need of his help, should Karna leave him & go to Pandavas? or should he stay loyal to Duryodhan? – was his first dilemma.

What did he choose ?

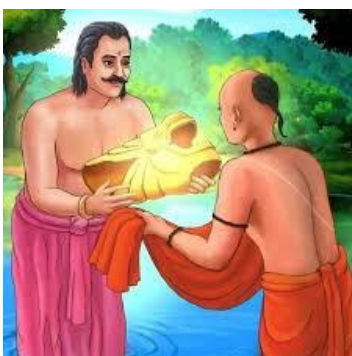
He chose to stay with Duryodhan rather than joining hands with Pandavas.

Why did he choose that?

Even after knowing the truth that he belonged to a clan which always chose the Dharma, he still chose to be the side of Adharmic and selfish friend. Both, Duryodhan and Karna was clear that their friendship has the base of revenge and arrogance; it was not a pure and self-less Dharmic friendship like Krishna and Arjuna.

Under the excuse of injustice being done to him since birth, Karna wanted a platform through which he can fulfil his malicious desire of destroying Arjuna & satisfy his arrogance. In the conflict between choosing Dharma and personal agenda, he kept himself above and chose personal agenda.

Dilemma 2: Should I Give Away My Kavach-Kundal To Indra Or Should I Deny?



Karna was undoubtedly a great warrior, with his kavach-kundal on him, it was almost impossible to win him, he was on the side of Adharma. If Dharma has to win, Karna needs to give up his kavach-kundal [natural armour]. Which is why, Indra in disguise of a Brahmin approached Karna and asked for his kavach kundal as a donation.

Here comes the second dilemma of Karna, whether should he give away his Kavach Kundal and protect his image as '*Daanveer*' or

should he let his image tarnish and protect his friend Duryodhan by winning the war with the help of Kavach-Kundal.

What did he choose?

He chose to protect his own image of '*Daanveer*' by giving away his Kavach-Kundal.

Why did he choose that?

Karna was well aware that his divine armours make him invincible & this is the reason why Duryodhan needed him more than anybody else to win this war. In the conflict between choosing his family and Duryodhan, Karna chose Duryodhan, though it was for his selfish reason but he promised a victory in the war. Now again when his armours are being demanded, instead of saving them as an instrument to win the war, he became ready to give them as alms, just to save his image of '*Daanveer*'. It is clear that in the conflict between choosing Duryodhan and himself, he chose himself and his own image.

Dilemma 3: Should I kill Arjun unfairly & win the war or should I give him a fair chance?



From day one, the sole purpose of Karna's life had been- the defeat of Arjuna. Finally, the moment has arrived when in the war, when Arjuna was on the point of Karna and could've been easily targeted and killed, doing so the war will end and Kauravas might have won the war.

At this point, Karna faces a dilemma whether should he kill Arjuna without alarming him, breaking the rule of war? Or whether he should warn Arjuna and give him a fair chance of duel, which might jeopardize their victory.

What did he choose?

He chose to give Arjuna a fair chance rather than killing him & winning the war.

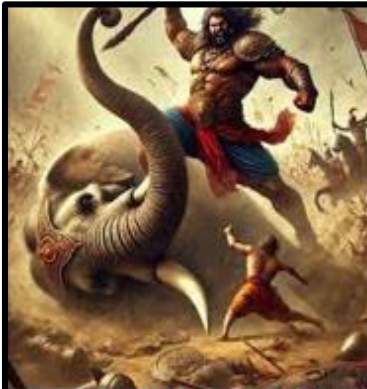
Why did he choose that?

Karna gave upon his mother, Shri Krishna, Dharma, all his brother and family & stayed loyal to Duryodhan. They had a common enemy, Arjuna. It was a known fact to all, laying down Arjuna will make them win the war. When Karna got a chance to kill Arjuna, he again chose his own image instead of choosing Duryodhan. Instead of killing Arjuna and winning the war for Duryodhan, he thought, Arjun will still be a hero even after his death due to being killed without a fair chance to fight. And Karna, even after killing Arjuna will be considered as a coward to have attacked him from back to win the war.

This thought process of keeping one's own image in the priority rather than his duty as a friend and warrior made him took this decision. He failed to choose the greater good.

Comparative Analysis of all the dilemmas and their decisions

Below mentioned is the comparative analysis of all the decisions taken by all the heroes whenever in dilemmas. This comparison shows us who chose the Dharma [Greater good] and who chose personal agenda, family etc. [Lower good]



Yudhishtira



Personal Desire Vs
Finding a mid way for the
greater good



Personal achievement Vs
Following the Dharma

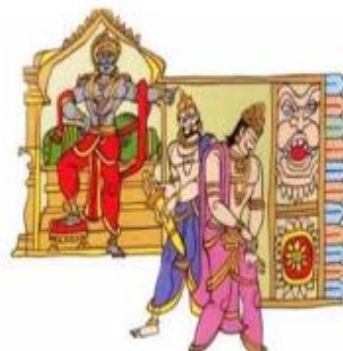
Personal Desire Vs
Maintaining Legacy as Kshatriya King



Saving oneself Vs
Saving the kingdom



Vibhishana



Choosing family Vs Choosing Dharma



Staying with the
family Vs
Staying with the
Dharma



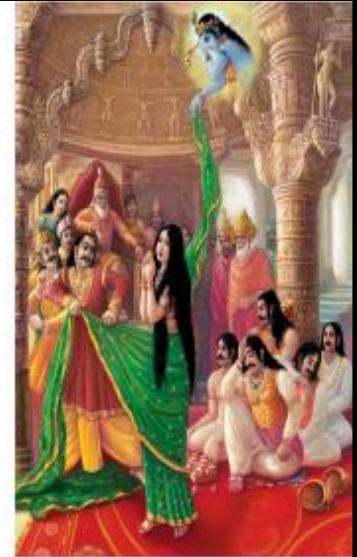
Choosing Kingdom
Vs Father



Bhishma



Choosing my faithfulness towards the king
Vs
choosing Dharma for the greater good



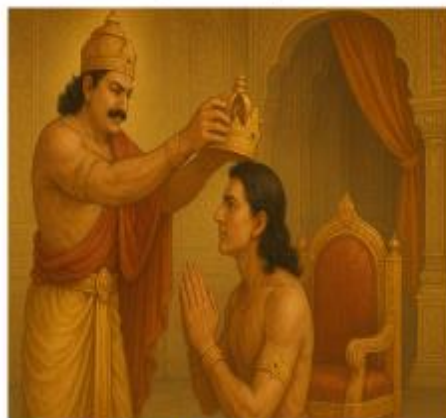
Choosing my loyalty [pledge]
towards the king Vs
Choosing Dharma towards
protecting a woman
[greater good]



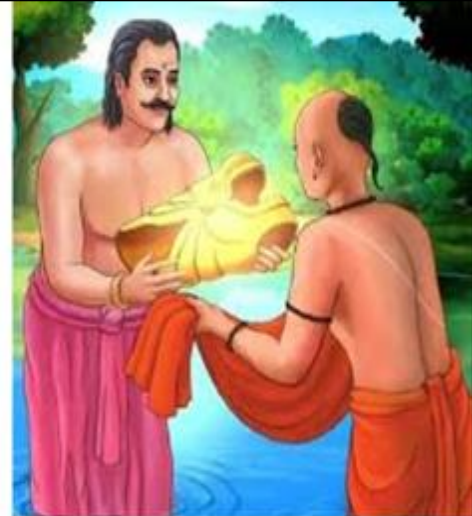
Choosing personal
image Vs Choosing
the victory of the
Kingdom



Karna

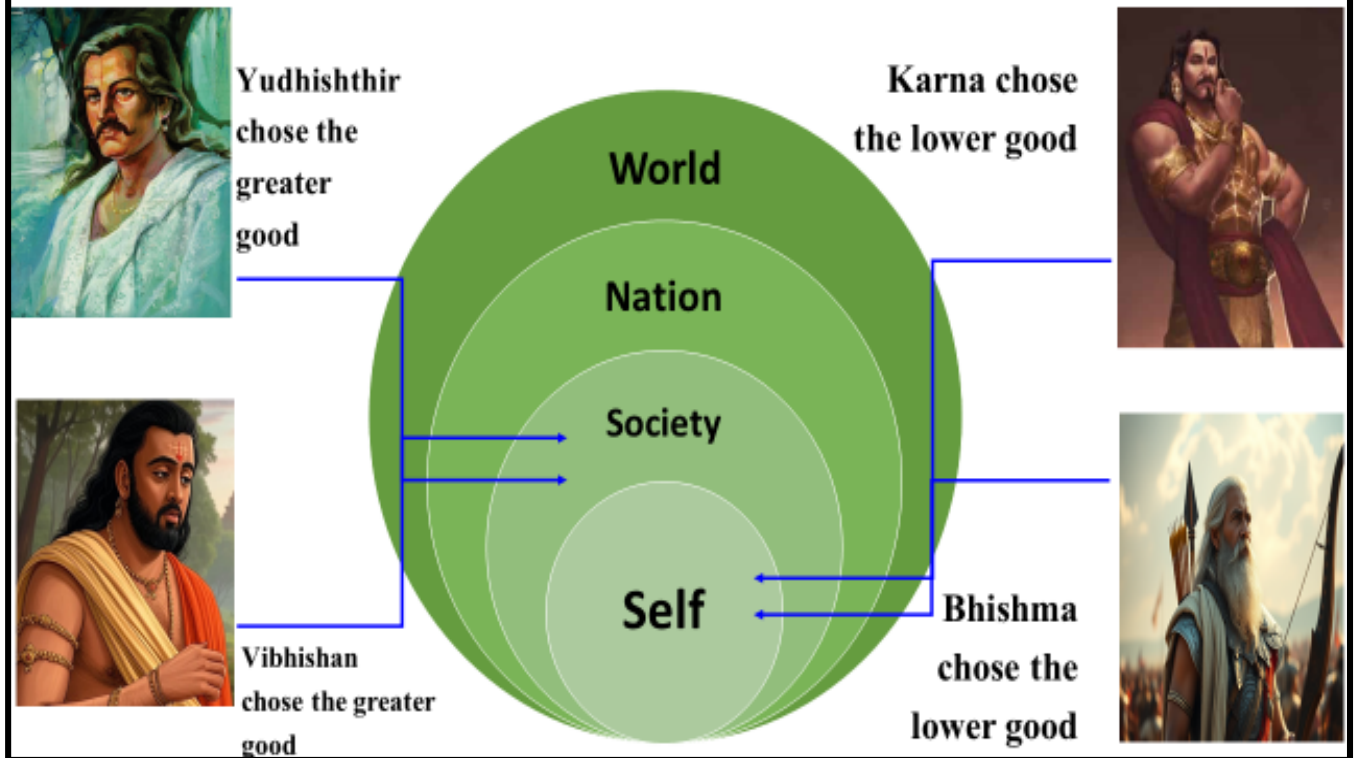


Personal agenda Vs Family



Choosing personal image Vs
Choosing his duty towards
Duryodhan and kingdom

Dharma is the “Greater Good”



Dharma is always choosing the greater good

Society is greater than self, Nation is greater than society and world is greater than Nation. Dharma is not always truth, it is not always right or wrong, it is not choosing convenience or mid-way. These stories show that dilemmas are not always about good vs. evil — they are about choosing between two “rights”, or sometimes, the lesser wrong. In every dilemma, Dharma is choosing the greater good.

The key question is:

“Will my decision serve only myself — or will it serve a higher purpose?”

Key Takeaways

- **Dharma is choosing the greater good**, even if it comes at a personal cost.
- **Your decisions define you** more than your intentions.
- **Truth, compassion, and justice** must outweigh convenience and loyalty.
- **Epics are not outdated** — they are case studies of the human mind in conflict.